INTRODUCTION TO HOLY SCRIPTURES



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CHAPTER ONE

- Etymological Definition
- The terms Bible, Scripture, Holy, and Sacred all have etymological roots that shed light on their meaning in religious contexts.
- Bible: The term "Bible" comes from the Greek word "biblia," which means "books." The plural form of the word is used because the Bible is made up of multiple books, each of which is considered to be inspired by God and authoritative for Christian belief and practice.
- The word "biblia" itself comes from the word "biblion," which means "a scroll or papyrus document." In this sense, the term "Bible" refers to a collection of sacred writings that have been assembled into a single volume.

Scripture:

- The word "Scripture" comes from the Latin word "scriptura," which means "writing or the act of writing."
- ." In religious contexts, the term "Scripture" refers to the written texts that are considered to be inspired by God and authoritative for faith and practice. The idea of Scripture as a source of authority has been central to many religious traditions throughout history, including Christianity, Judaism, and Islam.
- The terms Bible and Scripture are often used interchangeably, but they have slightly different meanings and connotations.

"Bible"



- The term "Bible" refers specifically to the collection of sacred writings that are considered authoritative for Christian belief and practice.
- The Bible is a compilation of 81 books, written over a period of thousands of years, by different authors, and in different languages.
- The books are grouped into two main sections: the Old Testament and the New Testament.
- The term "Bible" is used to describe this specific collection of books, and it is considered to be the primary source of authority for Christian belief and practice.

"Scripture"

- On the other hand, the term "Scripture" is more general and can refer to any sacred writing that is considered to be inspired by God and authoritative for religious belief and practice.
- While the Bible is certainly a type of scripture, there are other scriptures in various religious traditions, such as the Quran in Islam or the Vedas in Hinduism.
- Holy: The word "holy" comes from the Old English word "halig," which means "consecrated or sacred."
- The terms "Holy Bible" and "Holy Scripture" are both used to refer to the collection of sacred writings that are considered authoritative for Christian belief and practice.
- However, there are some differences in how the terms are used and what they emphasize.

"Holy Bible"

- The term "Holy Bible" specifically emphasizes the idea that this collection of writings is sacred and authoritative.
- On the other hand, the term "Holy Scripture" is more general and can refer to any sacred writing that is considered authoritative for religious belief and practice.

"Holy Bible"



- In religious contexts, the term "holy" refers to something that is set apart for a sacred purpose.
- Sacred: The word "sacred" comes from the Latin word "sacer," which means "holy or consecrated."
- In summary, the etymological meanings of these terms suggest that the Bible and Scripture are collections of sacred writings that are considered to be authoritative for religious belief and practice.
- The terms Holy and Sacred refer to things that are set apart for a sacred purpose and are associated with religious beliefs and practices.
- Understanding the etymology of these terms can help us to better understand their meaning in religious contexts

Holy Scripture

- In studying the definition of Holy Scripture, it is important to consider the historical and cultural context in which it was written, as well as the various interpretive approaches that have been used to understand it.
- The Orthodox Church views Holy Scripture as the inspired word of God, containing the revelation of God's plan for the salvation of humanity.
- It is understood to be a product of both divine and human authorship, with the human authors being inspired by the Holy Spirit to write what they did.
- As such, the Orthodox Church believes that Holy Scripture is the source of authority for Christian belief and practice.

Holy Scripture

- In addition to the written text of Holy Scripture, the Orthodox Church also recognizes the importance of tradition in interpreting and understanding the meaning of the Bible.
- Tradition is understood to be the collective wisdom and practice of the Church, which has been passed down through the ages and is guided by the Holy Spirit.
- Overall, the definition of Holy Scripture for the Orthodox Church emphasizes the importance of both the written text and the interpretive tradition of the Church in understanding and living out the Christian faith.

Holy Scripture

- Here are some other common names for the Holy Bible:
- 1. The Book of Books
- 2. The Good Book
- 3. The Holy Scriptures
- 4. The Old and New Testaments
- 5. The Gospel
- 6. The Living Word
- 7. The Sacred Writings
- 8. The Inspired Word
- 9. The Holy Word
- 10. The Book of Truth

1. The Book of Books

- "The Book of Books" is a term that is sometimes used to refer to the Holy Bible. The term is meant to convey the idea that the Bible is the most important and influential book in human history, and that it serves as the foundation for many of the world's major religions.
- The term "Book of Books" may also suggest that the Bible is a compilation of many different books, each with its own unique style, message, and purpose
- Overall, "The Book of Books" is a term that highlights the significance of the Bible as a timeless and influential work of literature and religious text.

1. The Book of Books

- Here are some additional meanings and interpretations of the term "The Book of Books":
- • The most widely-read book in history: The Bible has been translated into hundreds of languages and has been read by billions of people throughout history.
- • The source of religious authority:
- • The story of God's relationship with humanity:

2. The Good Book

- 2. The Good Book
- "The Good Book" is a common nickname for the Holy Bible, and is used to express a sense of admiration and respect for the book. Here are a few possible interpretations of the term:
- A book of moral and spiritual guidance: Many people refer to the Bible as "The Good Book" because they believe it contains valuable guidance for leading a moral and virtuous life.
- The Bible is full of teachings on love, compassion, forgiveness, and other virtues that are widely admired.
- A book of comfort and hope:

2. The Good Book

- A book of great literature:
- generally reflects a sense of respect and admiration for the Bible's teachings, history, and enduring significance.
- A book of redemption:
- A book of miracles:
- A source of wisdom:

3. The Living Word

"The Living Word" is a term used to describe Jesus Christ, as well as the Bible as a whole. Here are some possible interpretations of the term:

- A reference to Jesus Christ: In the Christian faith, Jesus is often referred to as "The Living Word," because he is seen as the embodiment of God's message to humanity. According to the Gospel of John, "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (John 1:1).
- A reflection of God's ongoing presence in the world: For believers, "The Living Word" represents the idea that God continues to speak to humanity through the Bible and through the teachings of Jesus. The Bible is seen as a living document that can provide new insights and revelations to those who study it with an open mind and heart.

3. The Living Word -

- A reference to the Holy Spirit: In Christian traditions, "The Living Word" is seen as a way of describing the Holy Spirit, which is believed to be the ongoing presence of God in the world.
- The Holy Spirit is a guider that can help people understand the Bible's message and apply it to their lives.

4. The Book of truth

- "The Book of Truth" and the "Holy Bible" are terms that are sometimes used interchangeably, but they can also have different meanings depending on the context and religious tradition in question.
- In general, "The Book of Truth" emphasizes the idea that the Bible contains the truth about God and His plan for humanity.

WHY WE STUDY THE HOLY SCRIPTURE

- We study the scriptures
- Because they are containing the inspired word of God.
- Ignorance of scriptures is ignorance of Christ.
- The Church has always venerated the divine scriptures just as she venerates the body of the Lord.

CHAPTER TWO

The Two Testaments

- The Bible consists of two volumes or parts, the Old Testament and the New Testament. The term OT and NT came into general use since the time of Tertullian, by the end of 2"d cent. A.D. However, the two parts of the Bible are not "Testaments" in the ordinary sense of the term.

- When we consider the content of the Old Testament and the New Testament it is more significant to designate them as "the Old Covenant"' and "the New Covenant.
- A Covenant is an agreement or contract between two parties (it is a bilateral agreement).
- The biblical writers, in both the Old and New Testament, speak of a covenant between God and man.

- In the Old Testament; we find God making covenants with Noah (Gen. 9:3-17), Abraham (Gen 15:18-21), Moses at Sinai (Ex: 19:5-6), David and with the nation Israel, Isaac Gen.26;4,Jacob Gen.28;4 In all these covenants the initiative always came from God's side.

- The covenant is God's doing and God's gift. God is always the giver and man the receiver, it differed from human covenants. There are two types of covenants: unilateral covenant (unconditional) and bilateral covenant (conditional).
- The biblical covenants have three parts: a statement about God's saving act (what God brings to the agreement), a statement about what God expects from humanity in response, and a sign or

- **The Unity of the Two Testaments**

- Cyril emphasizes that "the entire Scripture is one book, and was spoken by the one Holy Spirit.
- The unity of the Bible is based on Christ; without him, it is difficult to view Leviticus, Proverbs, Ezekiel, Mark's gospel, the Acts of the Apostles or the first epistle of John as part of one Holy Book, the Bible.

- For Cyril, the Scriptures are the pillar of his thought, because he considers their texts to be inspired by the grace of the Holy Spirit, and to be the true documents for the "mystery" of Jesus Christ.
- Jesus Christ brings about the unity of the Scripture, because He is the endpoint and the fullness of Scripture.

- Everything in it is related to Him. In the end He is its sole object. Consequently, He is, so to speak, its whole exegesis

- The book of the Old Testament and the New Testaments are two parts of the same book. We can see some of their similarities and cohesions which attract us:

- A. Both deals with the same God: The most basic source of unity and the one unifying theme of biblical revelation is the one God himself. It is the same God who reveals himself in different ways in every pages of the bible. The God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob is the same God who speaks through Jesus in the New Testament.

- The God of Israel is the same to the God of Christianity.
- In both the Old Testament and the New Testament God himself is the savior and compassionate of his people (cf. Isa. 43:3, 1Tim. 2:3-4).
- The saving character of God was revealed in bringing Israel out of Egypt in the Old Testament, but it was revealed on a new level on the cross at Calvary(a hill near to Jerusalem where Jesus Christ was crucified) in the New Testament.

- There are some differences in the way God has chosen to affect his salvation in both parts of the bible. The differences are with regard to three basic areas;-

1. The bringer of salvation: in the Old Testament the bringer of salvation and mediator of covenant is Moses, Ex.5;4 but in the New Testament it is Jesus Christ himself. John 2;2, Nu.21,2-5,John 3,15-16

2. The way of salvation: in the Old Testament the way of salvation is obedience to the law and circumcision is the sign of the covenant, but in the New Testament it is faith in Jesus Christ which is a pure gift of God and baptism is the sacramental sign of the new covenant.
3. The heirs of salvation: in the Old Testament the heirs of salvation are the old Israelites, but in the New Testament it is the church of Christ. In this case there is a unity, continuity and all the same time there is transcendence.

B. Both Testaments Deals with a chosen Nation: The Old Testament deals with Israel, the people of God, their origin and history, victories and defeats and their ultimate aspirations. They are commissioned by God to carry on his mission in the world. Similarly in the New Testament the Christian church is tension chosen by God. It is the new Israel, the continuation and fulfillment of the old Israel.

c. Old Testament events are examples and models of New Testament events: many events in the life of Jesus Christ and in the experience of the Christian church can be seen as symbols and signs in the Old Testament. Jesus Christ's return from Egypt as a child subsequent to Joseph's dream that Herod had died his fast for 40 days in the desert and subsequent temptations are all, according to the Gospel writers, similar to experiences found in the history of Israel.

D. The Testament finds its Fulfillment in the New Testament:

Many prophecies and psalms of the OT are fulfilled in the NT and almost all the NT writers share such an outlook towards the Old Testament. Throughout the Gospel of St. Mathew we find OT passages scattered to prove that almost every event in the life of Jesus is a fulfillment of OT prophecy. This can be seen in other parts of the NT as well.

- The Old Testament is a long preparation for the NT, and the hopes and aspirations expressed in it bear fruit in the life and activities of Jesus Christ as narrated by the New Testament. Generally, the relationship between the two covenants is well summarized by the famous statement of Augustine: "... the old Testament revealed in the New, the New veiled in the Old..." or, as another has put it "the New is in the Old contained, and the

Old Testament as a Preparation for the New Testament

- The Old and the New Testaments are the two acts of the same play of salvation. Unless we understand the first act of the play we will not be able to follow fully the meaning of the second act.

- The OT recounts the preparatory phase of salvation history, the purpose of which was to make the way ready for Christ.
- In the OT we have the gradual unfolding of God's revelation and salvation which reaches its culmination in Jesus Christ who thus fulfils the plan of salvation begun in the Old Testament.

- The great themes of the OT find their transcendental fulfillment in Jesus Christ; thus the creation points to a new creation, the Exodus to a new-Exodus, and the covenant to a covenant.
- Hence, to understand who Jesus is and to enter into a living and personal relationship with him. We have to know what the OT is and

- **Bible as the Word of God in the words of Men**

- We give greater respect and reverence for the Bible than for any other hook in the world. This is because Bible is the inspired word of God.
- When we say that Bible is the inspired word of God, it means that God is the author of the Bible though he made use of human authors to communicate his salsify message.

- In this sense Bible has twofold authorship: Divine authorship as well as human authorship. In other words, Bible is word of God in the words of men.
- The Bible is the word of God incarnate in human words; this means that there are divine as well as human characteristics in the Bible.

- Since the word of God is committed to writing by human authors we can find there specifications on the part of human authors, for example, limitations of time, place, culture, language etc.
- No book in the history of the world has exerted as much influence on humanity and civilization as the Holy Bible.

- The Bible is unique in that it has God as its author and men as its writer. The 'dabar' occurs more than 1400 times in the Old Testament.
- The expression "the word of the Lord" occurs about 400 times this confirms that God is the source of the massage.

- **The Structure and Divisions of the Bible**

- The present structure of the Bible has been subject to several historical variations. The main division is between the Jewish scriptures and those which are exclusively Christian. These are known as respectively as the Old Testament and the New Testament.

- From the Old Testament the most of the orthodox churches and the Catholics accept a longer canon containing 46 books while the Jewish and most Protestants have a shorter canon consisting of 24 or 39 books.
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- **Old testaments Division**
- **The Jewish Tanak:**
- Tanak;- Ta means Torah- Low,
- Na means Nebiim-Prophetic text
- K means Kethubhim-Historical text
- The Jewish division of the Old Testament has three parts known as
- Torah (the Laws),
- Nebiim (the Prophets), and
- kethubhim (the Writings).

- Torah consisted of the first five books: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy.
- Nebiim included 8 books which were divided into the Former Prophets (Joshua, Judges, Samuel, Kings) and the Later prophets (Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel Twelve Minor Prophets).

- Kethubhim were the poetic books (Psalms, proverbs, Job and the so-called 5 rolls (meghilloth) = Song of Songs, Ruth, Lamentations, Ecclesiastes, Esther; and the 3 late narrative books=Daniel, Ezra-Nehemiah, Chronicles. Thus there were in all 24 books by Hebrew reckoning

- **The Orthodox Bible**
- The arrangement of books in the Orthodox bible is quite logical: Law, history, poetry or wisdom and prophecy. The same number of books when it was translated into Greek by the LXX; (3rdcent'B.C.) became 39 in number, because LXX divided the book of Samuel into 2, the Kings into 2, the minor Prophets into 12, Ezra Nehemiah into 2, and the Chronicles into 2. This Greek division of LXX is followed by the orthodox and Catholic Churches. These books are later known as the proto-canonical books.

- Moreover, the LXX later included some more books in its Greek translation which were not found in the Hebrew Bible. They were not generally considered by the Hebrew as authentic, but they were known as deutero-Canonical. Seven books are belonged to the Deutero-Canonical group.

- Two books of the Maccabees
- Tobit
- Judith
- Ecclesiasticus (or Sirach)
- Wisdom
- Baruch.

- All these Deutero-Canonical books are considered by the Orthodox and Roman Catholic churches as authentic or canonical and have been included in the Bible.

- **Divisions of the Catholic Bible**
- Law 5:
- Genesis
- Exodus
- Leviticus
- Numbers
- Deuteronomy

- Historical books, 16
- Joshua
- Judges
- Ruth
- Samuel 1
- Samuel 2
- Kings 1
- Chronicles 2
- Chronicles 1
- Kings 2

- Ezra
- Nehemiah
- Tobit
- Judith
- Esrher/Aster/
- Maccabees 2
- Maccabees 1

- Didactical books 7
- Job
- Psalms
- Proverbs
- Ecclesiates
- Song of songs
- Wisdom
- Sirach (Ecclesiaticus)

- Prophetic books 18
- Isaiah
- Jeremiah
- Lamentations
- Baruch
- Ezekiel
- Daniel
- The 12 minor prophets

- The Greek Orthodox Church accepts the same number of books as the RCC, PLUS.
- 1Esdras
- Prayer of Manasseh
- Psalm 151
- 3 Maccabees
- The Coptic Church accepts two more books from the N.T such as
- 1st epistle of clement
- 2nd epistle of clement

- **Division of the Ethiopian Orthodox Bible**

- Law 5
- Genesis
- Exodus
- Leviticus
- Numbers
- Deuteronomy
- **Historical Books 16**

- Joshua
- Judges
- Ruth
- 1 & 2 Samuel
- 1 & 2 kings
- 1 Chronicles
- 2 Chronicles
- Jubuilee
- Enoch l
- Ezra Nehemia

- 2nd Ezra & Ezra Sutuel
- Tobit
- Judith
- Esther
- 1 Maccabees
- 2 & 3 Maccabees

- Wisdom (Poetry) books, 8
- Job
- Psalms
- Proverbs
- Reproof
- Wisdom
- Ecclesiastes
- Song of songs
- Sirach

- Prophetic books 17
- Isaiah
- Jeremiah
- Ezekiel
- Daniel
- Hosea
- Amos
- Micah
- Joel

- Obadiah
- Jonah
- Nahum
- Habakkuk
- Zephaniah
- Haggai
- Zekariah
- Malachi
- Joseph ben Gurion

- **The Protestant Bible**
- The Calvinist's, Lutherans and all other protestant churches follow-the Hebrew Bible and they do not include the above seven Deutro-canonical books in their Bible.
- Thus, accordingly, we have 46 books of the Old Testament in the Orthodox, and Catholic Bible, 39 in the Protestant Bible based on the Greek division of the 'LXX, and 24 in the Hebrew Bible according to the Jewish division.

- **New Testament Division**
- The New Testament books are divided by the Christians in the same way as gospels, historical, didactical, and prophetical. Gospels are the 4 gospels. Historical book is Acts of the apostles, Didactic-'1'books are the 14 letters of Paul and the 7 general letters (the letter of James, the 2 letters of Peter, the 3 letters of John, the letter of Jude), Prophetical book is the Revelation of John.

- Moreover, the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahcdo Church accepts 8 more "bocks of church order which are included of the 27 books of the New Testament.
- The order of Zion
- Commandment (Tizaz)
- Gitzew
- Abtils
- 1st books covenant
- 2nd books of covenant
- Clement
- Didascalia

- The Synod (the order of Zion, Commandment. Gttzew and Abtilis) is a book of church order comprising an extensive collection of canons, prayers, and instructions. The book is attributed to Clement of Rome. Clement is a book in seven parts. The book of Covenant counted as two parts: the first part of 60 sections comprises mainly on church orders; section 61 is a discourse of the Lord to his disciples after his resurrection The Ethiopic Didasclia is a book of church order which is divided in to 43 chapters.

- The 12 apostles, the 72 disciples, St. Paul, Jacob Jesus' brother, have spoken and written and gave it to Clement the 43 sections of Didasclia being gathered in Jerusalem. This is happened after the teachings of Jesus to the people on church orders and the establishment of the church at Philippians that is after 22 years of Jesus' resurrection.

- From the whole Bible the Ethiopian orthodox Tewahedo church accept a longer canon containing 46+35=81 books while the Catholics 46+27=73. Jewish and most Protestants have a shorter canon consisting of 24 or 39 books from the O.T and for Protestants 27 from the New Testament

- **The Chapter and Verse Divisions of the Bible**
- Within the books of the Bible, there was originally no division, except in the case of the Psalms, which were always indicated as separate poems.
- The first indication of divisions within the books is seen regarding the New Testament books.

- In the 2nd cent. A.D. Tatian wrote marginal notes in the New Testament book. So also, a system of paragraphing was developed for the Gospels, known as "titloi" in Greek (Title). Several such paragraphs were put under a descriptive heading called "Kephalaion" (Chapter).
- The present division of the New Testament books into chapters is attributed to Stephen Langton, professor of Paris University and later archbishop of Canterbury, about 1216 A.D.

- Still smaller division of the books of the New Testament was that of the “stichoi” (lines or vesicles). These marks were introduced to help the reader by indicating where he might pause.
- They were shorter than our present verses. The chapters were divided into versicles in 1550 A.D. by Robert Stephen. His son Henry Stephen published the first New Testament in Greek with the division into versicles in As regards the Old Testament books.

- Hen Asher made a certain division in the 10th cent. A.D., but our modern usage was devised Rabbi Nathan in 1448, first being printed in 1524.
- The verse division in the Old Testament is attributed to Sanctes Pagninus.
- Thus from I6"century on wards we have the complete Bible divided into chapters and verses.

- **The Printed Bible**
- Johann Gutenberg of Mainz (Germany) was the inventor of printing. Bible was the first printed book.
- The first printed Bible was in Latin and the printing was done around the year 1456. In the period between 1456 and 1500 there appeared nearly one hundred editions of the Latin bible.
- The complete Hebrew Bible was published in I488.

- **How Did the Bible Originate or come to be?**

- Bible is the word of God in human words, God's communication to humans.
- When God speaks to humans it does not just fall from the sky. God does it through time, space, and culture..

- Bible grew out of a long process of God's people recounting from generation to generation, the stories of their experience of God, and God's relationship and communication with them.
- The biblical literature is believed to have been written from the time of Moses (ca. 1400 B.C.) until the time of John (ca. I00 A. D.).
- It covers a history of growth and development for about 1500 years

- Tradition, church teachings, and scripture are all important in Christianity.
- The church acknowledges the twofold reality the scripture and tradition. Sacred tradition and sacred scripture make up a single sacred deposit of the word of God which is entrusted to the church.

- Our church does not restrict divine revelation to the text alone. Divine revelation the source of both tradition and scripture. Most of the Bible grew out of a three way process:

- **Oral Tradition:** is the process of transmission of the church beliefs, doctrines, rituals, and scriptures from the original bearers of the biblical writers with the assistance of the Holy Spirit.

- People recounted the experiences and stories of their experiences with God and passed them to their children and grand children, who likewise passed them on to the next generation-by word of mouth when writing was not very common

- . It can be apostolic and post apostolic, it can be written and unwritten. It is the sum of all that has been handed down and as to its function in the church tradition can act both as memory of the past and as anticipation of the future.

- **Written Tradition:** When eventually, crises arose that threatened to destroy the faith heritage (Tradition) of the chosen people, trained scribes (people who knew of writing), combined and wrote down those experiences and stories of faith to preserve them for all time.

- **Edited Tradition:** is what in the course of time, the scribes and literary people, collected the various written traditions and sources, and grouped them together in various categories, and edited them to apply them to their own time and situation.

- **CHAPTER THREE**
- **INSPIRATION AND REVELATION**
- **Inspiration**
- Inspiration is a term which drives from Lateen “inspirer” means “to breath upon or into something.
- Some Scholars understand the word inspiration as referring to the spirits action in the lives of biblical writers such as the prophets, apostles and others,

- so that what the writes become the word of God as the basis of this understanding the scholars appeal to texts which speak of Gods prophets receiving message from the Lord which they subsequently wrote down Jer 36: 1-2, Eze, 11: 5, Mic. 3:8,2pet, 1:21,).

- Other Scholars build form the Pauline declaration, “All scriptures is inspired by God” (2 Tim 3:15).
- Based on this they assert that “inspiration” refers to a quality of the biblical writings themselves.
- Generally one could distinguish within the one act of inspiration as an active sense (the action of God),

- and a passive sense (the effect of God's action on the human author). In keeping with in this distinction we may define "inspiration" as primarily an activity, and secondarily as a deposit or effect writings.

- **Biblical Description of inspiration**
- Inspiration as applied to the bible refers to the God given authority of its teaching for the thought and life of the believer, inspiration in the Bible approaches in double authorship" God is the author of the Bible (not mean He dictates it or written it but it means he willed it into existence), and God is the originator.

- **Inspiration in the Old Testament**

- It is true that there is no explicit mention inspiration in the page of the Old Testament. However, there are many passages which hint at it. We learn, for example, that it was God who has caused Mosses to record certain events and laws (ex. 17:14,24:: ;34: 27).

- Hence it may be supposed that written texts existed and were attributed to mosses and ultimately to God's authority. We also find references to prophets writing down the word of the Lord which they had received (Isa.30:8, Jer. 30: 2, 36: 2, Hab. 2:2). Such writing had a special claim to be considered sacred and to be regarded as the word of God.

- The people of the Old Testament believed that God guided them through his spirit. The action of the spirit is .seen in different ways in the Old Testament.
- In the first place there is an inspiration to act (Judges 3:10) and an inspiration to speak, especially in the case of the prophets (2 Sam 23:2; Isa. 59:21; Ez. I 1:5).
- Then (here is an inspiration to write (Ex. 1 7:14).

- Thus we come to three forms of inspiration. The inspiration to act may be described as pastoral inspiration. which moved the pastors or leaders of the people of God. Then there is prophetic inspiration, enjoyed by the speakers of the word: prophets and apostles. Finally comes scriptural inspiration, the prolongation end completion of the other two. All three together form what we might describe as biblical inspiration.

- **Inspiration in the New Testament**

- There are two most important texts in the New Testament (2 Tim. 3:16-17 and 2 Pet. 1:20-21), which with reference to the Old Testament, consider respectively the extent and the nature of inspiration.

- 2 Tim 3:16-11: "All scripture (pasa graphe) is inspires by God (theopneustos) and profitable for reaching, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work".

The Greek expression 'pasa graphe: most likely means 'every passage of scripture. The Greek adjective theopneustos is composed of theos, from theos,' '"God", and pneustos, from pneo, “to breathe”, it is generally understood in the passive sense, meaning that the scripture is "breathed out by God", “God breathed"', that is, the scripture is the product of the creative breath of God.

In other words, what is declared by this important passage is that the biblical books are a divine product, without indicating how God has operated in producing them.

In the Bible, the "breath of God" is the symbol of his almighty power, which is expressed through his creative word. In Ps. 33:6 we read: "By the word of the Lord the heavens were made, their entire host by the breath

- Here God's breath is seen as the irresistible outflow of his power. When Paul declares that every scripture is the product of the divine breath; he asserts that scripture is the product of a specifically divine operation.
- The spirit in the Old Testament is the creative power of God as expressed in the lives and words of Israel's great prophets.

Hence 2 Tim would be affirming that every passage in The Old Testament is God-breathed, or inspired; as a consequence these scriptures are useful for leaching, reproof, correction, and training in righteousness.

2 Pet 1:19-21: 'And we have the prophetic word made more sure[1]. You will do well to pay attention to this as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in our hearts.

- First of all you must understand this that no prophecy of scripture is a matter of one's own interpretation, because no prophecy ever came by the impulse of man.
- but men moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God.
- What Paul tells us about the divine origin of the scripture is confirmed and complemented by 2 Pet 1:19-21.

In this letter the author is confronting the troublemaking false teachers who claim that the traditional teachings about Jesus' Parousia are not heavenly revelations but only human creations (cf. 2 Pet 3:1-4; 1:16).

Peter is assuring his readers that what had been known to them of "The power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ" (2 pet 1:16) was not based on cleverly devised myth (1:16).

- He gives them the testimony of eyewitnesses of Christ's glory (l: 16-18). Then he tells them that they have better testimony than even that of eyewitnesses. "We have the prophetic word"; and this, he says, is "more sure", and therefore should certainly be heeded. The reason why every prophecy of scripture should be heeded to is that it does not come '"by the impulse of man"; that is, it is not the result' of human investigation nor the product of the writer's own thinking, but it is the result of God's action.

- **Support for the biblical claim of Inspiration**
- There are two lines of evidence to be considered on the inspiration of the bible: the evidence flowing from within scripture (internal evidence) and that coming from outside (external evidence).

- **Internal/evidence**
- The bible claims to be and proves to be the word of God. There are general claims for the bible as whole and more specific claims for sections and even individual books. This is true of both Old and New Testaments.

Support for bible's claim to be the written word of God comes from many sources. First, from the very nature of the bible, it gives every appearance of having come from God. Not only does in claim to have a divine origin, but also a supernatural character

Second, the witness of the spirit to the heart of the believer adds further confirmation to the bible's inspiration. Third, (he transforming ability of scripture is indication of its divine origin. Fourth, the very unity of the bible itself is another internal evidence for the inspiration of the bible.

- **External evidence**

The internal evidence of inspiration is mostly subjective in nature. It relates to what the believer sees or senses in his experience with the bible. All the internal evidences are available only inside Christianity. The nonbelievers does not sense the witness of the Holy 'Spirit, nor experience the edifying power of scripture .in his life.

- Unless he steps by faith to the inside, these internal evidences may have convincing effect on his life.
- This is where the external evidence plays a crucial role. It indicates where the 'inside' really is. The following are the external evidences:

- **First,** evidence from the historicity the bible: much of the bible is historical and as such is subject to historical investigation.
- The most significant area of confirmation in this regard has conies from the field of archaeology. The renowned archaeologist

- Scores of archaeological findings have been made which confirm in clear outline or exact detail historical statements in the bible." Clifford A. Wilson has added still more support to the historical reliability of the Bible.
- No historical discovery is a direct evidence of any spiritual claim in the bible, such as the claim to be divinely inspired; nevertheless the historicity of the bible does provide indirect verification of the claim of inspiration.

- **Second**, Evidence from prophecy: another forceful external testimony to the inspiration of scripture is the fact of fulfilled prophecy.
- According to mosses, "a prophet was false if he made predictions that were never fulfilled" (deut. 18)

- No unconditional prophecy of the bible about events to the present day has gone unfilled. Hundreds of predictions, some of them given.
- Hundreds of years in advance, have been literally fulfilled. The time (Dan. 9:25).

- The city (Mic. 5:2). And nature (Isa. 7:14) of Christ's birth were foretold in the Old Testament, as were dozens of other things about his life, death, and resurrection (lsa.'53).
- Numerous other prophecies have been fulfilled, including the destruction of Edom (Obad. J), the curse on Babylon (Isa. 13),

the destruction of Tyre (Eze. 26). And Neneveh (Neh. 1-3) and the return of Israel to the Land (Isa. 11:11). Other books claim divine inspiration, such as Quran, the book of Mermon and parts of the veda.

But none those books contains predictive prophecy. As a result, fulfilled prophecy is a strong indication of the unique, divine authority of the Bible.

- But none those books contains predictive prophecy. As a result, fulfilled prophecy is a strong indication of the unique, divine authority of the Bible.
- **Third,** Evidence from the influence of the bible: no book has' been more widely disseminated and has more broadly influenced the course of world events than office bible.

- The bible has been translated into more languages, been published in more copies, influenced more thought, inspired more art, and motivated more discoveries than any other book in history.
- The bible has been translated into over one thousand languages representing more than ninety percent of the world's population.

Fourth. Evidence from the apparent indestructibility of the bible: despite its importance, the bible has suffered more vicious attacks than would be expected to be made on such a book.

But the bible has withstood ail its attackers. Biblical critics once regarded much of it as mythological, but archaeology has established it as historical.

Antagonists have attacked its leaching as primitive, but moralists urge that its teaching on love be applied to modern society.

Skeptics have cast doubt on its authenticity, and yet more men are convinced of its truth today than ever.

An attack on the bible continues to arise from science, psychology, and political movements, but the bible remains undaunted.

The bible remains just as strong after the attack. Jesus said, "Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away" (Mark 13:31).

- **Fifth,** Evidence from miracles: another support for the inspiration of scripture comes from miracles.
- A miracle is an act of God and confirms the word of God by a prophet of God. The bible is a prophetic book.
- Every book in it was written by a prophet or apostle.
- And since there were miracles to confirm the prophetic message given by authors of scripture, then the bible is confirmed to be the word of God by acts of God (miracles).

- **Theological Description of Inspiration**

- The theological description of inspiration may be derived from three way of process.
- Divine Causality: The prime mover in inspiration is God: "No prophecy was ever made by an act of human will, but men moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God" (2 Pet 1:21).

- In other words, God moved, and the prophet mouthed the truths; God revealed, and man recorded hid word. The Bible is God's word in the sense that it originates with him and authorized by him, even though articulated by men.
- **Prophetic agency:** The prophets played an important role in the overall process of inspiration they were the means by which God spoke, The word of God was written by men of God used persons to convey His propositions, In other words, God exercised His operation in, with, and through the free working of man's own mind.

Scriptural authority: is the final product of God's causality and the prophetic agency. Hence the Bible is a divinely authoritative book.

God moved the prophets in such a way as to breathe out their writings. In other words God spoke to the prophets and is speaking in their writings.

- Therefore, this definition of inspiration is suggested in this way: inspiration is that mysterious process by which the divine causality worked through the human prophets without destroying their individual personalities and styles to produce divinely authoritative and inerrant writings.

- **Characteristics of inspiration**
- Once the bible is approved as the breath or inspired word of God, it has its own different characteristics. The following are some characteristics of inspiration:
- It is infallible
- It is unbreakable
- It is irrevocable (unchangeable)
- It is plenary on complete
- It has complete inerrancy

- **Revelation**
- The English word revelation conies from the Latin “revelo” or from Hebrew “galah” or from the Greek “apokalypto” which is mean to uncover and to unveil something hidden, so that it may be seen and known for what it is. Accordingly when the bible speaks of revelation the thought intended is of God the creator actively disclosing to men His power and glory, nature and character, will, way, plans, and in short himself in order that men may know him.

- The revelation in both testaments is a wide one covering the ideas of making: obscure things clear, bringing hidden things to light, showing signs, speaking words and causing the persons addressed to see, hear, perceive, understand and know.

The concept of revelation lies at the heart of the Christian faith. We believe that God has uniquely revealed Himself to humanity in the arena of human history.

We believe that God chose to reveal Himself to us and Christianity is a response to God's self disclosure in history.

- It is important to note that the content of revelation is not information or data, but God Himself. It is a self-revelation, self-disclosure, not revelation about things or ideas.
- Scripture itself is a direct revelation by God. God reveled Himself through scriptures. God is the one who reveled himself and scripture tells us towards that revelation.

- **The necessity of revelation**

The Bible assumes throughout that God must first disclose himself before men can know him. The Aristotelian idea of an inactive God whom man can discover by following out an argument is quite unbiblical.

- A revelatory initiative is needed, first, because God is transcendent. He is so far from man in his mode of being that man cannot see him (Jn. 1:18, Tim. 6:16. Ex. 33:20), nor find him out by searching (cf. Jb. 11:7, 23:3-9), nor read his thoughts by shrewd guesswork (Is.55:8).

- Generally speaking Revelation has two local points: God's purposes and God's person. This is mean:
- A). on the one hand, God tells men about himself who he is, what he has done, what he is doing, and will do, and what he requires them to do. Thus he took Noah, Abraham and Moses in to his confidence, telling them what he had planned and what their part in his plan was to be (Gen. 6:13-21, 12:1, Gen15:13-21, 17:15-21,18:l7, Ex. 3:7-22). Again, he declared to Israel the laws and promises of his covenant (Ex. 20-23, Dt. 4:13, 28, Ps. 78:5, 147:19).

- Jesus Christ told his disciples 'all that I have heard from my father' (Jn. 15:15), and promised them the Holy Spirit to complete his work of instructing them (Jn. 16:21).
- God revealed to Paul the 'mystery' of his eternal purpose in Christ (Ephe.1;9,

B. On the other hand, when God sends men his word, he also confronts them with himself.

The Bible does not think of revelation as a mere broadcasting of information, but as God's personal coming to individuals to make himself known to them (Gen. 35:7; Ex. 6:3).

- **The Biblical process of Divine Revelation**

God spoke to the prophets in many and varies ways (Heb. 1:1, Num. 12:6). The following are the different ways that God has revealed to humankind.

He spoke to prophets by angels, as he did to Lot (Gen. 19)

In dreams as he did to Daniel (Dan. 7:1)

In visions as he did with Isaiah and Ezekiel (Isa. 1:1, Eze. 1:1)

By using miracles eg. Moses and the burning bush (Ex. 3:2)

- **The Relation B/n Inspiration, Revelation, & Interpretation**
- Revelation concerns the origin of truth (1 Cor. 2:10). Revelation involves disclosure rather than discovery. Revelation refers to the divine disclosure of the scripture. Sometimes it can be a disclosure of a person (Christ).

- Even though the three concepts (inspiration, revelation, and interpretation) are interrelated in the total process of God's communication, they are quite distinguishable. God revealed truth to men who received and recorded it; and Inspiration becomes the means God. Used to achieve His revelation in the bible. Inspiration involves man in an active sense, where as revelation is solely the activity of God.

- **Interpretation** focuses on the apprehension and understanding of the truth. The Greek term hermeneuein is applied to the interpretation of the scripture in the study of hermcncucics. In revelation God unveils truth; by interpretation man understands that truth.

- The three concepts (inspiration, revelation, and interpretation) from three necessary links in the communication chain "from God to us”
- Revelation is the fact of divine communication
- Inspiration is the means of divine communication
- Interpretation is the process of understan ding that divine communication.

The Apocryphal Gospels

- The Apocryphal Gospels, as we have seen, may be divided into three classes:
- (1) Those which possibly preserve elements of genuine tradition.
- (2) Heretical Gospels, i.e. Gospels in which the narrative has been pur- posely altered to suit the tenets of some heretical sect.
- (3) Legendary Gospels, which embroider the account of the beginning and end of Christ's life with fictitious stories.

I. The Gospel According to the Hebrews

- The only Gospel which has any serious claim to be regarded as genuine and reliable is the Gospel according to the Hebrews. Unfortunately, however, we only possess a few fragments of it, culled from the writings of various Fathers of the Church. The most important and interesting of these are:
- Two references to the Baptism of Jesus
- An extract containing an account of the visit of the rich young man to Christ, which proceeds upon the lines of Matt. xix. 16-22, but adds the following words
- A fragment recording the appearance of Jesus to James after the Resurrection
- The following post - Resurrection utterance of Jesus
- A few sayings of Jesus

Heretical Gospels

- **III. The Gospel According St. Peter**
- The most interesting of all the heretical Gospels is that ascribed to Peter, a large fragment of which was recently discovered by the French Archaeological Mission, in a tomb at Akmim (Pentapolis), in Upper Egypt, and published in 1892. The fragment, unfortunately, only covers the last scenes in the life of Christ.
- It begins with the trial before Pilate, and ends with the visit of the women to the empty tomb on Easter morning.

VI. The Legendary Gospels

- We possess some twenty-two documents — most of them belonging to a late date—which expand certain parts of the history of Christ's life by the addition of legendary embellishments. They may be divided into three classes: (a) Those which deal with the history of Joseph and Mary before the birth of Jesus, {b) Those which deal with the infancy and boyhood of Jesus, {c) Those which relate to the history of Pilate.
- The Gospel of the Virgin Birth
- The Gospel of the Pseudo-Matthew
- The Gospel of the Nativity of Mary
- The History of Joseph the Carpenter
- Assumption of Mary
- The Gospels of the Boyhood Jesus
- Gospels Related to Pilate
- Gospel of Nicodemus

APOCRYPHAL ACTS, EPISTLES, ETC

- Apocryphal Act
- The Acts of Paul
- The Acts of Thomas
- The Acts of Andrew
- The Acts of John
- The Acts of Philip
- The Acts of Peter and Paul
-
-

Apocryphal Epistles

- The Correspondence between Jesus and Abgarus
- The Epistle of Paul to the Laodiceans
- The Correspondence between Paul and Seneca
- The Apocalypse of Peter
- The Apocalypse of Paul

Pseudepigrapha

- In addition to the books commonly called Apocrypha there is a wide variety of other ancient literatures, both Jewish and Christian, to which the name *pseudepigrapha* is often applied.
- Apocrypha, *pseudepigrapha* sectarian literature from the Qumran Caves, and a wide variety of other ancient writings provide helpful material for understanding the world of the New Testament and the early church. While not a par/*equivalence* with inspired Scripture, such writings merit examination.
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Canonization

- **4.1. Canonization of the Bible**
- Canonization is the process by which the Books of the Bible receive their final approval and acceptance by the church leaders.
- How did the Books of the Bible come to be accepted as part of the canon of the Scripture?
- How would one recognize an inspired book if he saw it?
- What are the characteristics which distinguish a divine declaration from a purely human one?
- Several criteria were involved in this recognition process. The people of God had to look for certain earmarks of divine authority.

Canonicity

- False books and false writings were not scarce. Their ever-present threat made it necessary for the people of God to carefully review their sacred collection. Sacred writings are two categories to be examined: books accepted by some believers, but not others; and writings once accepted but later questioned.
- Manuscripts from both categories were examined by church councils to verify whether they should be part of the Bible.

4.3. Basic Criteria for Canonization

- There are five basic criteria. These are Authoritative, Prophetic, Authentic, Dynamic and Accepted.
- **1.The Authority of the Bible**
- Each book in the bible bears the claim of divine authority. Often the explicit "thus says the Lord" is present. Sometimes the tone and exhortation reveal in divine origin. Always there is divine pronouncement. In the more didactic (teaching) literature there is divine pronouncement about what believers should be.
- In the historical books the exhortations are more implied and the authoritative pronouncements are more what God has done in the history of his people. If a book lacked the authority of God, it was not considered canonical and was rejected from being included in the Bible.
- Let us illustrate this principle of authority as it relates to the canon. The Books of the prophets were easily recognized by this principle of authority. The repeated "And the Lord said unto me," or "The word of the Lord came to me," is abundant evidence of their claim to divine authority.

2.The Prophetic Authority of the Book

- Inspired books come only through spirit–moved men known as prophets (2Pet 1: 20, 21). The word of God is given to His people only through His prophets. Every biblical author had a prophetic gift or function, even if he was not a prophet by occupation (Heb 1:1).
- St. Paul argued in Galatians his teachings and writings should be accepted because he was an apostle, neither from men nor through man, through Jesus Christ and God the Father (Gal 1:1).
- His book (epistle) was to be accepted because it was apostolic-it was from God-appointed spokesman or prophet.

3.The Authenticity of a Book

- Another hallmark of inspiration is authenticity. Any book with factual or doctrinal errors (judged by previous revelations) could not be inspired of God. God cannot lie; His word must be true and consistent. In view of this principle, the Bereans accepted Paul's teachings and searched the Scriptures to see whether or not what St. Paul taught them was really in occurred with God's revelation in the Old Testament (Acts 17:11).
- Simple agreement with previous revelation would not by itself make a teaching inspired. But contradiction of a previous revelation would clearly indicate that a teaching was not inspired.

4.The Dynamic Nature of the Book

- The fourth test for canonicity was not as evident as some of the others. This was the life-transforming ability (dynamic) of the writing. "*The word of God is alive and powerful*" (Heb 4:12).
- As a result it can be used "*for teaching, for correction and for training in righteousness*" (2Tim 3:16,17). The Apostle Paul revealed that the life-transforming ability of inspired writings was involved in the acceptance of all scripture; 2Tim 3:16,17 indicates this. St. Paul wrote Timothy, "*the Holy scriptures…are able to make you wise unto salvation*" Elsewhere, Peter speaks of edifying and evangelizing power of the word (1Pet 1: 23; 2: 2).

5.The Acceptance of the Book

- Ezra was the first one to canonize the Bible; The final trademark of an authoritative writing is its recognition by the people of God to whom it was initially given. God's word given through His prophet and with His truth must be recognized by His people. Later generation of believers sought to verify this fact.
- For if the book was received, collected and used as God's word by those to whom it was originally given, then its canonicity was established. Communication and transportation being what it was in ancient times, it sometimes, took much time and effort on the part of church fathers to determine this recognition. For this reason the full and final recognition by the whole church of the 66 books of the canon took many, many centuries.

The History of Canonization of the Bible

- Ezra was the first one to canonize the Holy Bible; he canonized the five Books of Moses. When they were finished by Moses, they were carefully deposited by the side of the Ark of the Covenant (Deut. xxxi. 24, 25, 26). "And it came to pass, when Moses had made an end of writing the words of this Law in a book, until they were finished, that Moses commanded the Levites which bore the ark of the covenant of the Lord, saying, take this book or the Law, and put it in the side of the ark of the covenant of the Lord your God, that it may be there for a witness against you."
- All Scriptures are written with the inspiration of the spirit of God or are the breath of God. They are also described as Holy Books containing the word of God (*Fitehanegest article-2*). The Holy Books are breath of God or are written under the inspiration of the Spirit of God. St. Paul sates in 2Timothy 3:16 "*all Scriptures are God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness.*" Saint Cyril of Alexandria also wrote that *"Holy Books are the breaths of God."* (Faith of Fathers 78:67). Hence, all that is written in the Scriptures is the absolute truth. Nothing can be added or deducted from it. It can neither be modified nor changed. It was written by Holy men guided by the Spirit of God (2Pet.1:20; Mat 5:18; Luke 16:17).

4.3.1. The Canon of Laodicea (A.D. 363)

- Let neither private psalms nor any uncanonica books be read in church, but only the canonical ones of the New and Old Testament (Canon 59).
- After listing the books of the Old Testament, the canon continues saying lists of the New Testament: four Gospels, according to Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John; the Acts of the Apostles, seven Catholic Epistles, namely, one of James, two of Peter, three of John, one of Jude; fourteen Epistles of Paul, one of James, two to the Corinthians, one to the Galatians, one to the Ephesians, one to the Philippians, one to the Colossians, two to the Thessalonians, one to the Hebrews, two to Timothy, one to Titus, and one to Philemon (Canon 60).

4.3.2. The Canon of Athanasius (A.D. 367)

- Again (after a list of the Old Testament books) it is not tedious to speak of the books of the New Testament. These are, the four Gospels, according to Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John. After these, the Acts of the Apostles and Epistles called Catholic, of the seven apostles: of James, One; of Peter, two; of John, three; after these, one of Jude. In addition, there are fourteen Epistles of Paul the apostle, written in this order: the first, to the Romans; then, two to the Corinthians; after these, to the Galatians; next, to the Ephesians; then, to the Philippians; then, to the Colossians; after these, two of the Thessalonians; and that to the Hebrews; and again, two to Timothy; one to Titus; and lastly, that to Philemon and the Revelation of John. These are fountains of Salvation that who thirsts may be satisfied with the living words they contain. In these alone the teaching of godliness is proclaimed: *Let no one add to these; let nothing be taken away from them*.

(A.D. 329-89)

- This canon, included among Gregory's poems (I, xii. 5 ff.), was ratified by the Trullan Synod in 692. It is in iambic verse, the lineation of which (but not the rhythm) is preserved, so far as possible, in the translation. Only the New Testament part is given here. [List to books of the Old Testament....]. But now count also [the books] of the New mystery; Matthew indeed wrote for the Hebrews the wonderful works of Christ, and mark for Italy, Luke for Greece, John, the great preacher, for all, walking in heaven. The Acts of the Holy apostles, the fourteen Epistles of St. Paul, seven universal Epistles; these are James, one and two of Peter, three of John and that of Jude's single epistle. If there is any besides these, it is not among the genuine books.

4.3.4. The Canon of the Third Synod of Carthage (A.D. 397

- The first council that accepted the present canon of the books of the New Testament was the Synod of Hippo in North Africa (A.D. 393); the acts of this council, however, are lost. A brief summary of the acts was read at and accepted by the Synod of Carthage, A.D. 397. Besides the canonical Scriptures, nothing shall be read in church under the name of divine Scriptures (Canon-24). Moreover, the canonical Scriptures are these: (then follows a list of Old Testament books).
- The books of the New Testament: the Gospels, four books, the Acts of the Apostles, one book; the Epistles of Paul, thirteen, of the same to the Hebrews one Epistle, of Peter, two of John, apostle, three; of James, one: of Jude, one; the Revelation of John. On the anniversaries of martyrs, their acts shall also be read.

Canonization of the Holy Scriptures

- **a. Clement (1st Century C.E.):** the third bishop of Rome and author of a letter (1 Clement) written to the church at Corinth about 95 C.E.
- **b. Ignatius (35-107 C.E.):** Bishop of Antioch in Syria and author of letters to several churches; Ephesians, Magnasians, Trallians, Romans, Philadelphians, Smyrneans. He also wrote a letter to Polycarp, bishop of Smyrna,
- **c. Muratorian Canon:** The oldest extant list of New Testament writings, discovered in the 18th Century by L.A. Muratori in an 8th Century manuscript. The list generally thought to date from the 2nd Century.
- **d. Tatian (2nd Century C.E.):** A native of Assyria, Tatian was a Christian apologist and author of the Diatessaron, a history of the life of Christ compiled from the four gospels and used in the Syriac church until the 5th Century C.E.):

- **e. Irenaeus (Ca. 130-200 C.E.):** Bishop of Lyon, Gaul (France). Around AD 185, Irenaeus claimed that there were exactly four Gospels, no more and no less, as a touchstone/*criterion* of orthodoxy. He argued that it was illogical to reject Acts of the Apostles but accept the Gospel of Luke, as both were from the same author.
- In Against Heresies, he ridiculed those who think they are wiser than the Apostles because they were still under Jewish influence. This was crucial to refuting Marcion's anti-Judaizing, as Acts gibes/*jeers* honour to James, Peter, John and Paul alike. At the time, Jewish Christians tended to honour James (a prominent Christian in Jerusalem described in the New Testament as an apostle and pillar, and by Eusebius and other church historians as the first Bishop of Jerusalem) but not Paul, while Pauline Christianity tended to honor Paul more than James.
- **f. Eusebius of Caesarea (CA. 260-340 C.E.):** His Ecclesiastical History, a multivolume history of the church down to ca. 300, was published ca. 325 C.E.
- **g. Constantine (CA. 274-337 C.E.):** Roman emperor whose policy was to unite the Christian church to the secular State by the closest possible ties. His laws and letters are a chief primary source for the relations of Christianity and the State from 313 onwards.
- **h. Council of Nicaea (325 C.E.):** The first ecumenical council of the Christian church called by Emperor Constantine who feared that disputes within the church would cause disorder in the empire. The Nicene Creed was formulated with its canons.

Bible

- So long as the living voice of prophets and apostles was to be heard, there was no pressing need of a canon of Scripture. Under the inspiration of God they knew what was inspired, and what was not. But as soon as these men were dead—and with them inspiration to these particular people ceased—it became necessary that their writings be gathered together to know what their messages to the churches were, and to preserve those writings from corruption.
- Another reason why a canon was necessary was to preclude/*prevent* the possibility of additions to the number of inspired works. Already numerous writings were extant purporting to be inspired. Hence the question arose, Which of these are really inspired? What is the extent of inspired literature?
- Still another and potent reason for the formation of the canon lay in the fact that the Emperor Diocletian issued in A.D. 302 an edict that all the sacred books should be destroyed by fire. Hence the question arose as to which books rightly deserved the name of inspired and sacred.

4.6. OLD Testament Canon.

- The formation of the Old Testament canon was gradual, and was composed of the writings which spread over many centuries. The approximate time line for the formation of the OT canon is 1600-1400 years. Moses commanded that the books of the law be placed in the ark (Deuteronomy 31:9, 26, Cf. 2 Kings 22:8 Joshua 24:26; 2 Samuel 10:25.)
- Then were gathered and placed in the temple the historical and prophetical books from Joshua to David's time. On the construction of the temple Solomon deposited in it the earlier books (2Kings 22:3, Isaiah 34:16), and enriched the collection with inspired writings from his own pen, and also some prophetic writings. So we find Daniel (9:2 R.V.) referring to "the books," Isaiah to "The book of the Lord" (29:18, 34: 16).
- After Solomon's day a succession of prophets arose, Jonah, Amos, Isaiah, Hosea, Joel, Micah, Nahum, Zephaniah, Jeremiah, Obadiah, and Habakkuk. These all flourished before the destruction of the temple, and enlarged the collection of existing sacred books by valuable additions.
- After the Babylonian capture, when the temple was rebuilt and worship re-established, then doubtless were added the writings of Haggai and Zechariah. About fifty years after the temple was rebuilt Ezra made a collection of the sacred writings (Neh. 8:2,3,14). To this collection were added the writings of Nehemiah, Malachi, and Ezra. It is a fact of history that Nehemiah gathered the "Acts of the kings and the Prophets, and those of David," when founding a library for the second temple, 432 B.C. (See 2 Maccabees 2:13).
- The canon of the Old Testament in the form we now have it, was the work of Ezra and the Great Synagogue. This fact is borne witness to in the most ancient Jewish writings. The Great Synagogue was composed of Ezra, Nehemiah, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi. There is no doubt but that such a collection of books existed in the time of our Lord and the apostles (Luke 24:27, 44).

4.7. The New Testament Canon

- The persecution of Diocletian (302 A.D.) brought to the front the question of the sacred literature of the church. The persecutors demanded that the Scriptures should be given up. This Christians refused to do. Hence the question became urgent-what books are apostolic? The answer lies in our New Testament. There were at that time many false and spurious gospels and epistles. Careful, prayerful, and deliberate examination, however, proved which were genuine and which were false. The genuine were received by the church as the inspired writings of the apostles and others whose names the books bear. Thus arose the New Testament canon.
- There is much evidence to indicate that the Canon of the Old Testament was fixed by about the year 400 B.C. largely as a result of the work of Ezra and Nehemiah and a council of Jews known as the *Great Synagogue*, which met after the return from the Babylonian captivity. Long before that time, however, many of the books we now have in the Old Testament had been agreed upon as inspired. In the case of the New Testament, the fixing of the Canon was done mainly at the council at Carthage in 387 A.D., although the evidence points to the selection of the books as early as about the year 100A.D.

Orthodox *Tewahdo* Church

- One Church which occupies a unique position in this regard is the Ethiopian Orthodox *Tewahdo* Church. Currently, it is the only Church whose Bible is comprised of 81 Books in total, 46 in the Old Testament, and 35 in the New Testament. It is also the biggest Bible, according to the number of books: Protestant Bibles usually contain 66 books, Roman Catholic Bibles 73, and Eastern Orthodox Bibles have around 76 books, sometimes more, sometimes less, depending on their belonging to the Greek Orthodox, Slavonic Orthodox, or Georgian Orthodox Church.
- And although the Ethiopian Orthodox Church belongs to the group of Oriental Orthodox Churches which are in communion with each other, there is no common consensus among them as to which books make up the Biblical canon; for example, the Coptic Orthodox Church has the same canon as Western Protestant Churches, with the addition of the two Epistles of Clement in the New Testament (a total of 68 books).

Tewahdo Church

- As mentioned above, the Bible of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church consists of 81 books, 46 in the Old Testament, and 35 in the new.4 With this, the Ethiopian Orthodox Church has the most extensive collection of Biblical books considered to be canonical of all the major Christian denominations.5 The number of books as well as the exact titles are laid down in the *Feteha Negest* (Law of the Kings), a book of law used in Christian Ethiopia since at least the 16th century, based on an Arabic manuscript written by a Christian Egyptian in 1238, which lists the books of the Bible. In Section 2, it states the number is to be 81; the actual titles of the books are mentioned in the text as well as in "Reading and Explanation of the *Feteha Negest*" (a kind of commentary).
- It should not come as a surprise that most of the "additional" books (those not accepted by all or most other Churches) are books that either have been considered canonical Scripture by one or more of the other Churches at some point, and/or are summarized as Apocrypha or *Pseudepigrapha* by them today, meaning that they constitute the books about which there always has been a certain amount of discussion as to whether they actually should be considered as canonical or not. However, some of the books that we find in the Ethiopian Biblical canon do not fulfil these criteria, either, but are completely unique to that particular Church.

Books of the Old Testament

- In the official rendering, the number of the Old Testament books in the Ethiopian Orthodox Church is 46, divided into four sections. Those books include:
- **Books of Law (the 5 Books of Moses)**
- Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers and Deuteronomy.
- **II. Books of History**
- Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1st and 2nd Samuel, 1st and 2nd Kings, 1st and 2nd Chronicles (2nd Chronicles includes the Prayer of Manasseh), Ezra and Nehemiah, Ezra Sutuel and 2nd Ezra, Tobit, Judith, Esther, 1st Meqabeyan
- 2nd and 3rd Meqabeyan, Joseph Ben Guriyon, Jubilees and Enoch.
- **III. Books of Psalms (Songs) and Wisdom**
- Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Reproof ("Tsegats" in Ge'ez), Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, Wisdom (of Solomon) and Sirach.
- **IV. Books of Prophecy**
- Isaiah, Jeremiah (including Lamentations, the Remainder of Jeremiah, and Baruch), Ezekiel, Daniel (including Susannah, the Prayer of the Three Children, and Bel and the Dragon), Hosea, Amos, Micah, Joel, Obadiah, Jonah o Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah and Malachi.

Books of the New Testament

- **I.Gospels**
- Gospel of Matthew, Gospel of Mark, Gospel of Luke and Gospel of John.
- **II.History**
- Acts (of the Apostles)
- **III. Epistles of Paul**
- Romans, 1st Corinthians, 2nd Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, 1st Thessalonians, 2nd Thessalonians, 1st Timothy, 2nd Timothy, Tito, Philemon and Hebrews.
- **IV. Other Epistles**
- 1st Peter, 2nd Peter, 1st John, 2nd John, 3rd John, James (called “Yaqob” in Ge’ez) and ude.
- **V. Prophecy**
- Revelation of John
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- **VI. Books of Church Order**
- 1. The Order of Zion,
- 2. Commandments (Te’ezaz),
- 3. Abtils,
- 4. “Gitzew”,
- 5.1st Book of Covenant,
- 6.2nd Book of Covenant,
- 7. Clement and
- 8. Didascalia.